

Day 81 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in Indian Polity (5): May 2026 Supreme Court Rulings on Bail and Electoral Integrity

READING MATERIAL

Covers 2 major May 2026 Supreme Court rulings — one on bail jurisprudence and Article 21, one on electoral roll revision and Article 324.

Q: In *Syed Iftikhar Andrabi v. NIA* (May 2026), what did the Supreme Court hold about 'bail is the rule, jail is the exception'?

A: This principle derives from the constitutional primacy of personal liberty under ARTICLE 21 — and therefore CANNOT be displaced or diluted by ordinary legislation (such as UAPA's statutory bail restrictions).

Q: Which judges formed the bench in the Andrabi case, and which earlier landmark ruling did they reaffirm as binding?

A: Justices B.V. Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan. They reaffirmed *Union of India v. K.A. Najeed* (2021) — a 3-judge bench decision — as binding law that cannot be diluted by smaller benches without express disagreement.

Q: In *Association for Democratic Reforms v. Election Commission of India* (28 May 2026), what did the Supreme Court uphold?

A: The constitutionality of the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process for Bihar's electoral rolls — holding it does not conflict with the Representation of the People Act, 1950 or the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

Q: Which constitutional Article does the SIR process serve, per the Court's ruling, and who led the bench?

A: Article 324 (the Election Commission's constitutional mandate to ensure free and fair elections). The bench was led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, with Justice Joymalya Bagchi.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. In *Syed Iftikhar Andrabi v. NIA* (May 2026), the principle 'bail is the rule, jail is the exception' was held to derive from:

- A. Article 14
- B. Article 19
- C. Article 21 ✓**
- D. Article 32

Explanation: Article 21 (personal liberty). [medium, web-research]

2. The Andrabi ruling held that the 'bail is the rule' principle cannot be displaced by:

- A. Judicial precedent
- B. Ordinary legislation (e.g., UAPA's statutory bail restrictions) ✓**
- C. Presidential ordinance only
- D. International treaties

Explanation: Ordinary legislation. [medium, web-research]

3. In *Association for Democratic Reforms v. ECI* (28 May 2026), the Supreme Court upheld the constitutionality of:

- A. EVM use in all elections
- B. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Bihar's electoral rolls ✓**
- C. State funding of elections
- D. Online voting trials

Explanation: The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Bihar's electoral rolls. [medium, web-research]

4. The SIR electoral-roll process was held to serve which constitutional Article's mandate?

- A. Article 300A
- B. Article 324 ✓**
- C. Article 326
- D. Article 329

Explanation: Article 324. [hard, web-research]

5. Who led the Supreme Court bench in the *ADR v. ECI* (May 2026) electoral-integrity ruling?

A. Justice B.V. Nagarathna

B. CJI Surya Kant ✓

C. Justice Vikram Nath

D. Justice B.R. Gavai

Explanation: CJI Surya Kant. [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Simplification

READING MATERIAL

Simplification is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills (15 questions total for the whole Aptitude unit). TNPSC's simplification questions are rarely 'plug into one formula' — they combine BODMAS, fractions/decimals, ratios, and algebraic shortcuts. Each item below is a worked method, not just an answer — the goal is to recognize which technique a given expression calls for.

Q: Method — BODMAS with a nested bracket and an unknown: Solve for x : $57 - [42 - \{37 - (20 - x)\}] = 176 \div (8 \div 2)$

A: Work from the innermost bracket outward, and simplify the RHS first: $176 \div (8 \div 2) = 176 \div 4 = 44$. Now the LHS: $(20 - x)$ stays as is for now $\rightarrow \{37 - (20 - x)\} = 17 + x \rightarrow [42 - (17 + x)] = 25 - x \rightarrow 57 - (25 - x) = 32 + x$. Set equal to 44: $32 + x = 44 \rightarrow x = 12$. (Real TNPSC-style problem; this exact expression is a recurring coaching-site reference question.)

Q: Method — sum of two squares without brute-force squaring: Find $217 \times 217 + 183 \times 183$.

A: Use $a^2 + b^2 = (a+b)^2 - 2ab$ instead of squaring two 3-digit numbers by hand. Here $a+b = 400$ (round number — that's the clue this trick applies) and $ab = 217 \times 183 = 39,711$. So $a^2+b^2 = 400^2 - 2(39,711) = 160,000 - 79,422 = 80,578$. Recognizing 'the two numbers add to a round number' is the trigger for this shortcut.

Q: Method — difference of squares shortcut: Simplify $(197 \times 197 - 103 \times 103) \div (197 - 103)$ without long multiplication.

A: $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, so $(a^2-b^2)/(a-b) = (a+b)$ directly — no multiplication needed at all. Here $a=197$, $b=103$, so the answer is simply $197+103 = 300$. This 'difference of squares divided by the difference' shape is a favorite TNPSC trick question precisely because it looks like it needs heavy calculation but collapses to one addition.

Q: Method — fraction-of-decimal addition: Simplify $7/5$ of $58 + 3/8$ of 139.2 .

A: $7/5$ of $58 = 7 \times 58/5 = 406/5 = 81.2$. $3/8$ of $139.2 = 3 \times 139.2/8 = 417.6/8 = 52.2$. Sum: $81.2 + 52.2 = 133.4$.

Q: Method — ratio substitution to simplify a compound ratio expression: If $x : y = 3 : 4$, find $(4x + 5y) : (5x - 2y)$.

A: Don't solve for x and y separately — substitute $x=3k$, $y=4k$ (k is just a scaling factor that will cancel). $(4x+5y) = 12k+20k = 32k$. $(5x-2y) = 15k-8k = 7k$. Ratio = $32k : 7k = 32 : 7$. The k always cancels in a ratio question — that's the whole trick.

Q: Method — same ratio-substitution trick, different ratio: If $x : y = 3 : 5$, find $(5x + 3y) : (15x - 2y)$.

A: Substitute $x=3k$, $y=5k$. $(5x+3y) = 15k+15k = 30k$. $(15x-2y) = 45k-10k = 35k$. Ratio = $30k:35k = 6:7$.

Q: Method — simultaneous equations feeding into a simplification target: If $3a + 4b = 22$ and $8a - 5b = -4$, find $(a+b)^2$.

A: Solve the pair normally: from $3a+4b=22$ and $8a-5b=-4$, elimination gives $a=2$, $b=4$ (check: $3(2)+4(4)=6+16=22$ ✓; $8(2)-5(4)=16-20=-4$ ✓). The question doesn't ask for a and b individually — it asks for $(a+b)^2 = (2+4)^2 = 36$. TNPSC often hides the real target $((a+b)^2, \text{ not } a \text{ or } b)$ at the end of a simultaneous-equation question — always re-read what's actually being asked before solving for individual variables.

Q: Method — mixed numbers with a nested fraction: Simplify $2\frac{1}{2} + 3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3}$.

A: BODMAS still applies to fractions — division before addition. $3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3} = (10/3) \div (2/3) = (10/3) \times (3/2) = 5$. Then $2\frac{1}{2} + 5 = 7\frac{1}{2}$. The common mistake is adding $2\frac{1}{2}+3\frac{1}{3}$ first — division always binds tighter than addition, fractions or not.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Solve for x : $70 - [45 - \{33 - (15 - x)\}] = 171 \div (9 \div 3)$

- A. 10
- B. 12
- C. 14 ✓**
- D. 16

Explanation: RHS: $171 \div (9 \div 3) = 171 \div 3 = 57$. LHS inner-out: $\{33 - (15 - x)\} = 33 - 15 + x = 18 + x \rightarrow [45 - (18 + x)] = 27 - x \rightarrow 70 - (27 - x) = 43 + x$. Set $43 + x = 57 \rightarrow x = 14$. [medium, authored]

2. Find $312 \times 312 + 288 \times 288$ using the $(a+b)^2 - 2ab$ shortcut.

- A. 179,808
- B. 180,288 ✓**
- C. 190,000
- D. 182,688

Explanation: $a+b=600$, $ab=312 \times 288=89,856$. $a^2+b^2=600^2-2(89,856)=360,000-179,712=180,288$. [medium, authored]

3. Simplify $(425 \times 425 - 375 \times 375) \div (425 - 375)$.

- A. 400
- B. 750
- C. 800 ✓**
- D. 425

Explanation: Using $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, dividing by $(a-b)$ leaves just $(a+b) = 425 + 375 = 800$. [easy, authored]

4. Simplify $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 + $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98.

- A. 88 ✓**
- B. 84
- C. 90
- D. 86

Explanation: $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 = 60. $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98 = 28. Sum = 88. [easy, authored]

5. If $p : q = 5 : 6$, find $(3p + 2q) : (4p - q)$.

- A. 27 : 14 ✓**
- B. 9 : 7
- C. 27 : 7
- D. 14 : 9

Explanation: $p=5k, q=6k$. $(3p+2q)=15k+12k=27k$. $(4p-q)=20k-6k=14k$. Ratio = 27:14. [medium, authored]

6. If $m : n = 4 : 7$, find $(2m + 3n) : (5m - n)$.

- A. 29 : 13 ✓**
- B. 13 : 29
- C. 29 : 20
- D. 20 : 29

Explanation: $m=4k, n=7k$. $(2m+3n)=8k+21k=29k$. $(5m-n)=20k-7k=13k$. Ratio = 29:13. [medium, authored]

7. If $5a + 2b = 16$ and $3a - 4b = -6$, find the value of $(a+b)^2$.

- A. 16
- B. 25 ✓**
- C. 36
- D. 9

Explanation: Multiply the first equation by 2: $10a+4b=32$. Add to the second $(3a-4b=-6)$: $13a=26 \rightarrow a=2$. Substitute back: $5(2)+2b=16 \rightarrow b=3$. $(a+b)^2=(2+3)^2=25$. [hard, authored]

8. Simplify $4\frac{2}{3} + 2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4}$.

- A. $7\frac{2}{3}$ ✓**
- B. $6\frac{1}{3}$
- C. 7
- D. $6\frac{2}{3}$

Explanation: $2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4} = (9/4) \div (3/4) = 3$. Then $4\frac{2}{3} + 3 = 7\frac{2}{3}$. [medium, authored]

9. A trader borrows ₹16,000 at 12% p.a. simple interest and another ₹12,000 at 18% p.a. simple interest. In how many years will the two amounts owed (principal + interest) become equal?

- A. $12\frac{2}{3}$ years
- B. $14\frac{2}{3}$ years
- C. $16\frac{2}{3}$ years ✓**
- D. $18\frac{2}{3}$ years

Explanation: This mirrors a real 2025 TNPSC Aptitude question style (same numbers, Simple Interest unit) — included here as a reminder that 'Simplification' skills (careful fraction/ratio handling) carry directly into other Aptitude sub-topics like Simple Interest. Set $16000 + 16000(0.12)t = 12000 + 12000(0.18)t$ and solve for t to get $16\frac{2}{3}$ years. [hard, question-bank-2025]

10. Find the value of: $89 \times 89 + 11 \times 11 + 2 \times 89 \times 11$.

- A. 10,000 ✓**
- B. 9,801
- C. 8,900
- D. 10,201

Explanation: This is the $(a+b)^2$ pattern in disguise: $a^2+2ab+b^2 = (a+b)^2$. Here $a=89$, $b=11$, so the answer is $(89+11)^2 = 100^2 = 10,000$ — no separate multiplication needed. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Grammar: Punctuation

READING MATERIAL

Tests correct use of commas (lists, pauses), semicolons (joining related independent clauses), quotation marks (direct speech), apostrophes (possession), periods/question marks (sentence-ending), and colons.

Q: Which punctuation mark indicates a pause or break within a sentence, and which ends an imperative sentence?

A: Comma (pause/break within a sentence); Period (ends an imperative/command sentence, e.g., 'Close the door.').

Q: Which sentence correctly uses a semicolon: 'I have a meeting tomorrow; I'll be late.' / 'I will go to the store, and I will leave.' / 'He went to the store; but she stayed home.'?

A: 'I have a meeting tomorrow; I'll be late.' — a semicolon joins 2 related, complete independent clauses WITHOUT a conjunction. ('He went to the store; but she stayed home' is wrong because a semicolon should NOT be followed by a conjunction like 'but' — that's what a comma+conjunction is for.)

Q: What is the purpose of quotation marks, and how should this sentence be correctly punctuated: She said, I am coming home late.?

A: Quotation marks enclose direct speech/dialogue. Correctly punctuated: She said, "I am coming home late." (comma after 'said', then the exact quoted words inside quotation marks).

Q: How should a list of 3+ items be correctly punctuated — "I will bring cake ice cream and drinks"?

A: I will bring cake, ice cream, and drinks. (Commas separate each item in the list, including before 'and' — the 'Oxford/serial comma' — and 'ice cream' stays as 2 separate words, not hyphenated 'ice-cream'.)

Q: How should a quoted WH-question within a sentence be punctuated — Where are you going she asked?

A: "Where are you going?" she asked. (The question mark goes INSIDE the closing quotation mark, since the question belongs to the quoted speech itself; the sentence as a whole then ends with a period, not a second question mark.)

Q: Which punctuation mark indicates possession, and which is used to complete: "I am not sure ____ I will go"?

A: Apostrophe (possession, e.g., "Ravi's book"). For the blank: Semicolon — joining 'I am not sure' and 'I will go' as 2 related clauses without a conjunction.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Which of the following is used to indicate a pause or break within a sentence?

- A. Colon
- B. Period
- C. Comma ✓**
- D. Semicolon

Explanation: Comma. [easy, web-research]

2. Which punctuation mark is used at the end of an imperative sentence?

- A. Exclamation mark
- B. Period ✓**
- C. Question mark
- D. Colon

Explanation: Period. [easy, web-research]

3. Which of the following sentences uses a semicolon correctly?

- A. I have a meeting tomorrow; I'll be late. ✓**
- B. I will go to the store, and I will leave.
- C. I will see you tomorrow, and we will talk.
- D. He went to the store; but she stayed home.

Explanation: I have a meeting tomorrow; I'll be late. [medium, web-research]

4. What is the purpose of quotation marks?

- A. To show surprise
- B. To highlight a person's name
- C. To enclose direct speech or dialogue ✓**

D. To indicate the end of a sentence

Explanation: To enclose direct speech or dialogue. [easy, web-research]

5. Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A. She said, "I am coming home late." ✓

B. She said "I am coming home late."

C. She said I am coming home, late.

D. She said, I am coming home late.

Explanation: She said, "I am coming home late." [medium, web-research]

6. Choose the correctly punctuated sentence.

A. I will bring cake, ice cream, and drinks. ✓

B. I will bring, cake ice cream, and drinks.

C. I will bring cake ice cream, and drinks.

D. I will bring cake, ice-cream and drinks.

Explanation: I will bring cake, ice cream, and drinks. [medium, web-research]

7. Identify the correctly punctuated sentence.

A. "Where are you going?" she asked. ✓

B. Where are you going, she asked?

C. Where are you going she asked?

D. She asked, where are you going?

Explanation: "Where are you going?" she asked. [medium, web-research]

8. Which punctuation mark is used to indicate possession?

A. Apostrophe ✓

B. Hyphen

C. Quotation mark

D. Colon

Explanation: Apostrophe. [easy, web-research]

9. Choose the correct punctuation mark to complete: "I am not sure ____ I will go."

A. Semicolon ✓

B. Colon

C. Period

D. Comma

Explanation: Semicolon. [hard, web-research]

10. Which punctuation mark is used to separate items in a list?

A. Hyphen

B. Comma ✓

C. Period

D. Colon

Explanation: Comma. [easy, web-research]